

Productivity Tips

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Introduction

Nearly everyone wants to be more productive. There is a huge amount of advice on this. I want to share (and keep for my own reference) some strategies I found effective.¹ Before diving into more practical advice, it is worth considering what makes someone productive or unproductive and the broader goals.

I think it is important to consider why we aim to be productive. After all, with infinite time and no deadlines, productivity stops being important. But in reality, my personal philosophy is to use productivity as a tool to create free time for health, activities, and people you care about while still achieving your goals. To this end, explicitly or implicitly recognizing the things important to you can be productive. Being fast at responding to emails frees up more time for research. Being a productive researcher frees up time for friends and family.

When thinking about how to be productive, every strategy below does one of two things: it either lowers the barrier to start productive work, or raises the barrier to being unproductive. Pure discipline and rigid structure aren't sustainable on their own — willpower runs out — so the goal is to design your environment so that being productive takes less willpower to begin with.

Lower the barrier to start

Consolidate recurring effort into one-time effort

Often, replacing long-term recurring tasks with a single larger one-time task helps productivity. Even if the one-time task takes more effort up front, the mental energy and scheduling flexibility gained by not having to repeat it can outweigh the added time (within reasonable limits). What makes tasks hard is often their recurring nature — the consistent energy and commitment required to complete them even in weeks when other things matter more.

Money can be thought of as a conversion of effort. Spending money on recurring costs is the same as spending the time it took to earn that money. These transactions aren't always lossy — if the recurring cost is cheap, you earn enough, or you have enough spare time — but generally, the act of purchasing recurring items should also be considered part of its time cost. I have also found myself using fewer disposable items where possible, with the added benefit of eco-friendliness.

Automate or build a quick tool to outsource labor

Can I write a script or build a tool quickly to solve this? With generative AI and some simple scripting, it is becoming easier and easier to write small scripts. Although generative AI can sometimes struggle with larger projects, for smaller scripts it can be very convenient.

Simple emails can be responded to more quickly with generative AI and automatic responses. It can be unnecessarily floral, but this may not matter much in most settings, especially for short responses.

Google Calendar has an appointments feature through which other people can book your time. This saves the effort of managing your calendar and setting up appointments manually (which I always found got confusing and redundant quickly). I also use the tasks feature quite extensively. The integration with Thunderbird isn't the best by default, but Provider for Google Calendar seems to fill in the gaps.

¹Matt Might wrote an excellent post on his blog on this as well.

Favor simple, existing solutions

Try to keep solutions simple. Although it can be better to manage your own tools, also check for simple, readily available solutions first.

Eliminate redundancy for inevitable tasks

Is this tool redundant? I like to use a mail client, not for any composition feature, but because I can consolidate my email accounts across Gmail and Outlook and view them all in the same feed. Similarly, I would not purchase a dicer if I have a knife. A hybrid wok with a lid is also a great kitchen implement, since it can function as both a pot and a pan, and can handle many types of ranges. I personally prefer temperature- and scratch-resistant nonstick and silicone, since the time taken to clean stainless steel or maintain and season cast iron (not to mention it isn't easy to handle) makes it not worth it.

Redundancy can also create major problems, like inconsistencies between a CV and a website. In fact, this is why I created my website using Typst — so that I could update both at once (which I learned from brutal experience, having accidentally submitted a version of my CV with incorrect dates during grad school applications²). These sorts of things are inevitable, so eliminating redundancy here doesn't encourage laziness the way, say, owning too many plates does.

Weigh maintenance cost against benefits

Does owning a possession save me more time, energy, or effort than the effort required to maintain it? A good rule of thumb: is there another tool that does the same task with similar effort? In the kitchen, a good example is a knife. Most people only need one or two. As long as it's maintained, one well-kept chef's knife can handle nearly everything another knife can, so the time spent maintaining several specialized knives vastly outweighs the time saved by using each one for its "ideal" task. Watches have become largely useless in an era where everyone has a phone. Every item carries some burden on the mind, time, and energy. There is nothing wrong with any item inherently, but as an old Quaker saying about William Penn's sword put it, "hold it as long as thou canst."³

I used to feel obligated to hold onto possessions I owned or had been given, and felt very emotionally attached to them, but this ultimately created more clutter than it was worth. Worse, the emotional significance of each item was lessened, since I had so many. I am now much more intentional about giving and receiving gifts, and have shifted toward minimalism — valuing and using only the gifts that address a real need in my life.

Make productive behaviors easy to access

Make it easier to access productive behaviors. This is most obvious with food: if I keep healthy food around and prepared, I almost always find myself eating healthy without thinking about it. When I wanted to practice piano more during COVID, doing my work near the piano made me naturally play more, simply because I interacted with it so much. Neatness works the same way: a well-organized space lowers the barrier to starting work, since less effort gets wasted hunting for something buried in the mess, and fewer stray objects are around to catch your attention and pull it elsewhere.

Rely on habits

A habit is a task running on autopilot, so it costs almost no willpower to execute — the decision to do it has already been made in advance. This makes habits one of the most reliable ways to lower the barrier to starting: once brushing your teeth, doing a load of laundry, or reviewing your calendar becomes routine, you no longer spend energy deciding whether to do it. The

²Thankfully nearly every school let me submit a new version of my CV, since I had submitted everything several weeks early in case of disaster.

³<http://www.qhpress.org/quakerpages/qwhp/pennswor.htm>

upfront cost is building the habit in the first place, but that cost is paid once, while the savings compound every time after.

Raise the barrier to unproductivity

Create scarcity

I hate doing the dishes — enough that avoiding the sink is a bigger motivator than the mess itself. I care enough about the environment not to rely only on disposable utensils, so I eat out of a single microwaveable pasta bowl that doubles as a plate. Now I have to clean it right after use, or I won't have a bowl for the next meal — which also forces more intentional portions. This may not be practical for everyone, but it accomplishes the same effect: the barrier to being unproductive, or letting tasks accumulate, is diminished.

Reduce recurring energy costs

How much energy does keeping up with this task take? Is there a way to get out of it or consolidate it? One major drain of energy for me is notifications and emails. A few years ago, a two-week phone outage forced me to let people wait for responses, and I felt more focused and present as a result. That's not practical long-term, but it pushed me toward other cuts — like smartwatches, since phone fitness tracking now covers most of the same ground.

I interact with the internet mostly through RSS feeds and newsletters, but I was running into a few problems. My inbox was getting cluttered, and keeping it clean took sustained energy. I was also getting enough notifications in a day that I felt constantly tied to my phone to respond and deal with them. Most weren't important and didn't need a response, but deciding that still took consistent effort, especially for newsletters with irregular schedules. I found that making an aggregation tool like Mailbrew helped curb this. My biggest complaint was that the number of sources was limited and I couldn't set a digest for specific days of the week, but it serves the purpose well.⁴

Make unproductive behaviors hard to access

How does the accessibility of something change how I use it? If your phone is always nearby and fun to use, it's easy to reach for it. This, to some extent, is why social media is so addictive — it's easy to engage with endlessly and at no cost. So: block Instagram, YouTube, etc. on your phone. Unsubscribe and unfollow — every YouTube channel automatically generates an RSS feed you can subscribe to instead. XKCD had a similar idea for raising the barrier to browsing,⁵. I made such a firefox extension here:⁶. I've also found a slow, cheap phone with a small screen good at making phone activities less fun, while staying functional enough for email and messages. Put your phone away in class and while working. Leave it somewhere out of reach. You can always unblock these apps or sites, but having to do so every time creates enough friction to avoid compulsive checking.

Conclusion

Every strategy above comes down to one of two moves: make it easier to start doing the things that matter, and make it harder to drift into the things that don't. Consistency matters more in the long run than any single burst of motivation — a system you stick with beats a flash-in-the-pan effort you can't sustain. You will still deviate from these systems sometimes, and that's fine; a lapse is not a moral failure, just a data point. Becoming more productive is an ongoing endeavor — there are many strategies you can use, but in the end, don't chase perfection. The attempt itself is often a good start.

⁴<https://matt.might.net/articles/productivity-tips-hints-hacks-tricks-for-grad-students-academics/#procrastination>

⁵<https://blog.xkcd.com/2011/02/18/distraction-affliction-correction-extensio/?blogid=79314890&blogsub=confirming#subscribe-blog>

⁶<https://addons.mozilla.org/firefox/downloads/file/4936809/5a11dc9b78db4060a5ff-1.0.xpi>